

Northern Highlands Regional High School Home and School Association, Inc., (HASA) minutes of the general meeting held on September 16th, 2015.

Present at Meeting: Margaret Engkvist, Gloria Dreyer, Christy Soell, Michele Madonna-Scherreik, Glee Rogers, Maria DiMartino, Renee Buzzelli, Belinda Alward, Tracy Platt, Terry Madonna, Dana Sileo, Barbara Garand, Sheila Yallowitz, Christine Ferrarie, Sheryne Brekus, Fidelis Feeley-Corrie, Ariana DeLucia, Lisa Tantillo, Grace Valente, Sharon Holle, Bob Pash, Louise Basralian, Cathy Squasoni, Elaine Peebles, Sue Hynes, Mary Ellen Moschetta, Kathy Travers, Nancy Levin, Gina Grieco, Josephine Nirchio, Nancy Tarbutton, Jean Holden, Maria Abrahamsen, Lisa Ceccon, Andrea Pennington, Stacy Paton

Staff Present at Meeting: Dr. Scot Beckerman, Mr. Joe Occhino, Mr. Michael Koth, Ms. Kelly Peterfriend

President Stacy Paton called the meeting to order at 9:34 AM and began our first order of business which was introducing our new Superintendent, Dr. Scot Beckerman.

Superintendent's Report – Dr. Scot Beckerman: Dr. Beckerman thanked the HASA board for the Back to School Night Dinner we provided to the staff. He informed the group that he has a conflict and cannot attend the HASA Sponsored Freshman Parent Breakfast. Dr. Beckerman is spearheading the district's strategic planning process. The development of a 3-5 year strategic plan will begin on 1/20 and the key areas of focus are the state of the school, vision and dreams, and goals and destinies. The plan will cover facilities, academics and co-curricula's and the team will reflect on how to improve all three and implement a new and improved vision. The Strategic Planning team is looking for input from parents. The parents will be included in 3 planning meetings to be held on 1/20/16, 2/11/16 and 3/23/16. All sessions will be held in the auditorium at 7:00PM. Any interested parties should contact Dr. Beckerman with their contact information and you do not need to attend all 3 dates to participate. Dr. Beckerman also mentioned that there will be an electives audit. The purpose of this audit is to assess where we are with electives currently and delineate where we want to be moving forward. There will also be a student super forum. This Forum will be to get feedback from students at all levels and find out directly from them what Highlands does well and what we can improve on in the future. The superintendent's office is currently working on a district newsletter to be disseminated at a future date.

Principal's Report – Mr. Occhino: Mr. Occhino thanked everyone at Highlands for facilitating a great school year opening. Mr. Occhino mentioned that this past summer the summer assignments were revamped. The staff wanted to continue to focus on student wellness and they eased up on the summer assignments. He solicited feedback from the parents at the meeting with regard to this change. Most families loved the change noting that there was less stress between parents and their children over the summer due to the fact that they didn't have to pressure their kids to do their summer assignments. Parents did mention that maybe they could find a happy medium with regard to "summer slide" as many kids didn't do any reading at all this summer. Suggestions included reading a community book with no written assignment attached, suggested summer reading list – pick one book to read of the students' choice, college essay assignment for seniors.

Mr. Occhino explained that there were 5 major assessments to assess students in the past. There was a unit test after each unit, a project based assessment and a research based assessment. This year they will shift in what they are doing for assessments. There will be 9 assessments instead so teachers can assess what is necessary sooner and that will drive changes in instruction. General announcements made by Mr. Occhino were that the 8th grade visitation to the school is usually held earlier, but it had been changed to accommodate the 50th Anniversary celebration. PARCC results will be coming in late October or early November. The results from these tests will impact the graduation class of 2020, which is one year later than previously discussed. The Transition Project will be held on 9/18. This program is an outreach program with student ambassadors reaching out to freshmen. This program has been in existence for 10 years. This program has been very successful and helps freshmen feel at home and not looked down upon by upper classmen. The ambassadors help get the freshmen acclimated to the high school environment. Lastly, we are very proud of our Honor Roll Students. 563 students will be attending our Honor Roll Breakfast to be held on 9/17 at 7:15AM.

Vice Principal's Report – Mr. Koth: Mr. Koth announced that the 50th Anniversary Celebration will be on 9/26 at 11AM. Events will include an alumni open house, guided tours, and a varsity football game at 2:30PM. Former alumni, parents and staff are all invited for a complimentary BBQ as an additional part of the festivities. Please rsvp if you will be attending the BBQ at constancebanstra@gmail.com. "We can't wait to showcase our top rate programs, facilities, academics and great students at the celebration," he noted. Another exciting program coming soon is NHRS will host an assembly with FBI Director James Comey, a former 1978 Northern Highlands graduate. We will have a town hall style meeting and will get questions from the students for a Q & A for the meeting.

School Counseling/Guidance Report – Ms. Peterfriend: Elective changes deadline has passed. The students can still change academic placement at this time. All program dates are on the school counseling/guidance website. The school counselors have met with seniors and all new students. Important dates of interest include 9/17 College Fair at FDU. Bring return address labels to put on cards to fill out at the fair. 10/1 is the *First Step a 9th grade program including Naviance* which will be held in the auditorium at 7PM. Ms. Peterfriend also announced that guidance has addresses on social media. Follow them on Twitter at @NHGuidance and on Instagram. Mr. Occhino has a Twitter account as well. Follow him at @occhinoj on Twitter. The counselors will be going out to visit some California campuses soon. Reminders have been sent out to all seniors regarding deadlines for applications, written essays and teacher recommendations. A question was asked if Guidance would ever sponsor overnight trips to see college campuses. The response was that it would be too hard to coordinate at this time.

Board of Education Report – Jill Webb: Jill, Barbara Garand and Sheila Yallowitz are in attendance and are happy to be working with Dr. Scot Beckerman. The Board is happy to announce that there was a lot of facilities work done over the summer. They had a new heating/air conditioning unit installed in the Science Wing, new carpeting, and a new roof installed. Highlands has updated our wireless capabilities so we will be able to roll out our PC initiative next year successfully. Surface 3 computers will be utilized with 95% of the classes and will be keeping 3-5% of other options such as MAC's.

MPAA – Christy Soell: There will be a band competition coming up on 9/19 at 4:00PM on the field. We will be having a Wine Tasting Fundraiser at \$40.00 per person. 7 wines will be tasted with appetizers. The fundraiser will be held on October 14th. The November Fall play is in rehearsals now. The MPAA welcomes people to come attend their monthly meetings on the 2nd Monday of every month.

Sports Association – Bob Pash: The Sports Association is happy to announce that they have donated 4 portable, environmentally friendly lights to the BOE for use at NHRS. The lights will provide better light coverage for the athletes and students using the field. The new lights are expected to come within a few weeks. The lights cost over \$300,000. 80% of the funds are completed. The rest will have to be funded through a letter of credit unless we meet our goals through fundraising. The Sports Association is running a fundraising paver program for all communities. This program is a great way to preserve your family name. Please spread the word to help us light the dream. The portable lights can also be repurposed throughout the campus to other locations so all programs can use them. Also, membership forms are available to join the Sports Association. These funds that are acquired through membership help pay for additional things for the athletic programs at Highlands.

HASA President – Stacy Paton: Introduction of new members to the board. Encouraged everyone to attend the Freshman Parent Breakfast. Thanks to Nancy Levin for the refreshments for the meeting. Sign-up sheet for breakfast donations disseminated. Anyone signing up for refreshments will be reimbursed. Overview of what HASA provides to the school included - Planners for all students, Freshman Transition Project, Equipment for TV Studio, Planetarium movies, Speakers and more. Stacy extended thank you's to membership team, Louise Basralian for the coordination of the Freshman Breakfast, Christine Ferrarie for the HASA newsletter and Constant Contact emails and Sue Hynes for the website.

Treasurer's Report – Kathy Travers: Kathy provided report and mentioned that we would be saving money next year by NOT paying for planners. An App will be provided through our new computer initiative next year for a planner.

Grocery Card Chairperson – Andrea Pennington: Shop Rite, Stop and Shop and Fairway cards available today and flyers are available to send in orders.

Membership – Christy Soell and Michele Madonna: Please hand in your membership forms. We have 395 members to date.

Secretary – Andrea Pennington: Motion was made to approve minutes from June 2015 meeting – Ariana DeLucia. Gloria Dreyer seconded the motion.

Next meeting was announced for 10/14. Bob Williams is set to attend and present on the activities and athletics/clubs offered. Board was asked if they could post minutes from the meetings on the HASA website. The board will look into it. Meeting was adjourned.

**Consultation
on changes to the
Transport Policy for
Children and Young
People with Special
Educational Needs**

February 2014

Consultation Document

What are we proposing to do?

This consultation document is about proposed changes to the Transport Policy for children and young people with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND).

It is proposed that the county council:

- introduces a parental contribution for discretionary Post 16 transport support of £475 per annum with effect from September 2014.
- applies a formulaic increase to future years' concessionary charge that is on the basis of Retail Price Index (RPI) plus 5%.

The proposed changes would ensure that transport provision for children and young people with special educational needs and disabilities can continue to be provided in a transparent, supportive and cost-effective way for families.

It is proposed that the changes will be introduced from September 2014.

The county council wants to hear your views on these important proposals. If you have difficulty in accessing this information, please contact the Inclusion and Disability Support Service on:

Telephone 01772 532241 or 01772 530839 or email us at idss@lancashire.gov.uk

Foreword



In Lancashire, we believe that children and young people come first. We want them to enjoy their time at school, make good progress, and achieve their best. This is particularly so for those children and young people who have a special educational need or disability (SEND).

Lancashire County Council is facing cuts in funding of up to £300m over the coming years. Transporting children and young people with special educational needs and disabilities to and from school or college is very costly.

Over the last seven years the cost of home to school transport for children and young people who have a special educational need or disability has significantly increased. It is important that we work together to deliver high quality services to families in genuine need and reduce inefficiencies wherever possible.

The county council works together with parents and other service providers to help our children to be safe, to enjoy and achieve, to be listened to, to belong to the community and to achieve economic wellbeing.

I hope that you will take a little time during this consultation period to let us know your views on what we are proposing to do. We will not make a decision until we have carefully considered all responses to this consultation.

A handwritten signature in black ink, written over a horizontal line. The signature is stylized and appears to be 'Paul' followed by a flourish.

County Councillor Matthew Tomlinson
Cabinet Member for Children, Young People and Schools

PART ONE

Our vision and what we would like to achieve

Education is a powerful means of transforming and enriching lives and communities. Future success and well-being depends on new ways of working, high expectations and a belief that we all have a part to play and can make a difference together.

Most pupils who have a special educational need or disability will attend their local primary or secondary school; however, some pupils will attend a special school, or special unit in a mainstream school – this could be in Lancashire or further afield.

Some pupils are, or may be entitled to, transport assistance provided by the local authority to and from their school. Where this happens, our aim is to ensure that each child has suitable travel arrangements in place, which enable them to travel without stress, strain or difficulty, and in reasonable comfort and safety.

To determine each child's transport and travel needs, we look very carefully at what is said in their statement of special educational needs, and listen to the views of their parents or carers, and the relevant professionals. There is a need to improve and simplify this process so that families understand what transport assistance they can expect to receive.

Where it is appropriate we want to encourage progression to independent travelling, in a phased, supported way. This can increase confidence in using public transport, increasing participation in community life and can help to prepare a young person for life beyond school and college.

Overall our policy, when compared to other local authorities, is quite generous in that it extends beyond the legal duty placed upon the county council to provide home to school transport. For example, current entitlement applies to children over 16 years attending further education (FE) provision and provides free transport support for young people starting a new course aged 16 to 24 with special educational needs or disabilities to attend school or college.

By continuing to heavily subsidise this support we will maintain our commitment to shield families from the full cost of tailoring transport to their children's needs.

PART TWO

Proposal

It was agreed on the 5 December 2013 by the Cabinet Member for Children, Young People and Schools to consult on changes to the Transport Policy for Children and Young People with Special Educational Needs and Disabilities (SEND).

It is proposed that the County Council:

- introduces a parental contribution for discretionary Post 16 transport support of £475 per annum with effect from September 2014.
- applies a formulaic increase to future years' concessionary charge that is on the basis of Retail Price Index (RPI) plus 5%.

The cost of providing home to school transport for children and young people with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND) in the financial year 2012/13 was £16.26 million. 2,907 pupils currently receive free travel to school or college, the majority of them attending special schools. The average annual cost per pupil to provide SEN transport is approximately £5,500; the proposed charge of £475 per annum represents a small proportion of the average costs per pupil.

Local authorities have certain statutory responsibilities around home to school transport and have the discretion to offer additional provision where deemed appropriate. 83% of the overall current costs of transport provision were spent on statutory transport responsibilities; the remainder being spent on non-statutory (discretionary) transport provision.

In view of the considerable financial pressures which the County Council faces, both currently and in the foreseeable future, we need to review the Home to School Transport Policy for Children and Young People with SEND with a view to identifying possible savings.

Home to school/college transport support for post 16 young people with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND) is a discretionary policy area. The current Home to School Transport Policy for children and young people with special educational needs and disabilities provides discretionary door to door transport for young people aged between 16 and 19 where they meet the eligibility criteria which applies to those pupils aged under 16.

Requests for post 16 SEND transport assessments have increased three-fold since the policy was amended in 2008 in favour of free transport for all eligible SEND learners aged 16 to 24 which increased the home to school/college transport costs for children and young people over 16, with SEND to c£2.5m per annum.

~~The number of pupils who received discretionary free travel in 2012/13 was 493 at a cost to the County Council of £2.74 million.~~

~~Mainstream post-16 students in Lancashire attending school sixth forms and further education colleges do not receive any financial support from the Council to fund their transport costs.~~

~~Given the overall financial position of the Council and in developing options for amending post-16 SEND transport support, consideration has been given to the national picture where a significant number of local authorities ask for a contribution towards transport support for post 16 young people with SEND (for example, Northamptonshire, Worcestershire, Calderdale, Devon, Essex, Norfolk, Staffordshire, Warwickshire).~~

~~Consideration has also been given to the importance of enabling students to access further education. To mitigate the impact of the financial contribution it is proposed that Post 16 SEND students from low income families (defined by entitlement to free school meals or parents/carers in receipt of maximum levels of working tax credit) would be exempt from the charge.~~

~~Implementation of the proposed contribution would still result in the County Council providing a large subsidy to support transport for the most vulnerable students who, due to the impact of impairment or disabling circumstances, cannot safely travel by other means to the nearest available establishment that meets their identified learning needs.~~

~~We wish to hear your views on the introduction of a parental contribution to apply to discretionary post 16 SEND transport as set out above with effect from September 2014.~~

PART THREE

The consultation and decision making process

Timescales

3 February 2014 to 25 April 2014	Consultation (12 weeks)
26 April 2014 to May 2014	Consultation feedback reviewed and proposals amended if necessary
May 2014	Cabinet Member decision making session to consider the results of the consultation and decide whether to proceed with the proposals
June 2014	2014 Transport Policy for children and young people with special educational needs and disabilities published
September 2014	Implementation

Who we will consult

This consultation document will be provided to people and organisations who may have an interest in these proposals.

These include the following:

- Parents/guardians/carers of children and young people who receive transport support.
- Lancashire Parent Carer Forum.
- Headteachers and chairs of governors of special schools across the county.
- Lancashire further education providers.
- Independent, non-maintained special schools where LCC pupils are placed.
- Local authorities which maintain a statement of educational need for children attending a school within the county or who may be affected by the proposals.
- Other local authorities bordering Lancashire.
- Lancashire Youth Council.
- Family Information Service.
- Lancashire Welfare Rights Service.
- The wider community through 'Have your Say' website
www.lancashire.gov.uk/haveyoursay

Your Response

~~As stated earlier in this document, we welcome your views on this proposal and all observations and objections will be considered very carefully before any decision is made to progress any further.~~

~~The consultation runs until 25 April 2014 and you can respond by completing the questionnaire in this document or writing separately:~~

~~By Post to:
Corporate Research and Intelligence (Room A39)
Lancashire County Council
County Hall
PR1 0LD~~

~~By Email to: ids@lancashire.gov.uk~~

~~Online at: www.lancashire.gov.uk/haveyoursay~~

~~The information provided in this document is intended to be sufficient for people to form a view on the proposal. However, at this stage we need to listen to your views and concerns so that the detailed proposals which we make later in the process can take these into account.~~

~~We are sorry that due to the volume of responses we receive when consulting on proposals we will not be able to acknowledge written responses nor enter into correspondence with interested parties during or after the consultation period. We have included any relevant frequently asked questions (FAQs) with answers within this document and this will also be posted on the council website at: www.lancashire.gov.uk/haveyoursay~~

Thank you

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